LEADING HEART CARE IN INDIA OVER THE DECADES

A well known expert in cardiac sciences and interventional cardiology, Dr Suman Bhandari, a senior cardiologist and Director Cardiology at Fortis Escorts Heart Institute, Okhla, New Delhi. His experience in the speciality spans over 47 years, which makes him an institution in himself. Dr Bhandari discusses a wide gamut on the scenario of heart care. Some excerpts.



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What is your perspective on the evolution of cardiology, now enhanced by technology?

The science of cardiology has matured significantly as compared to my early days at AIIMS while training in cardiology. Cardiology was very basic until around 80's when changes set in after AIIMS acquired one of the first echo cardiogram in India followed by the Holter. Coronary angiogram and by-pass surgery developed in 1980-85, but it was still nascent. A breakthrough came with balloon mitral valvuloplasty in 1985 and soon the coronary scene changed to balloon and then bare metal, and finally the drug eluting stents in 2002. Devices like rotablator, other atherectomy and thrombectomy devices and lately intravascular lithotripsy for removing calcification are now available. Surgeries also moved from on-pump to beating heart that gave less post- operative strokes. Bypass surgery has matured and a short period of going robotic was not followed aggressively due to better results by human hands.

We are also doing percutaneous aortic valve replacement, a revolutionary intervention, meant for the elderly. Earlier, doctors rejected 40-50 percent operations on patients beyond 75, because of age-related complications and co-morbidities, but now they can get operated and lead a normal life, despite aortic stenosis.

What are the most modern improvements in Cathlab and drugs?

As refinement happened in technology, the Cathlabs became more-friendly, emitted less radiation, and gave more accuracy in diagnosis. Today, you have intravascular ultra sound, OCT, physiological tools to assess stenosis severity in lab itself. AI is entering into Cath lab, driving precision, safety and giving quicker results.

Earlier heart failure was seen as terminal, but now new drugs can raise the pumping of the heart, while some people also become normal. So also better drugs for high cholesterol, blood pressure etc., are entering the field.

How did the private healthcare sector bring in change?

Private healthcare sector ushered innovation at a faster pace, introduced healthy competition and ensured significant career growth for the doctors based on merit unlike government hospitals where they have a hierarchical system of career elevation. Private hospitals have to be more enterprising and out-perform to survive, like the Escorts Heart Institute, a pioneering standalone cardiac centre established in 1988, which later became a multi-speciality with many centres across India.

Highlight some landmark achievements in your long career?

Among my life's milestones is doing Cardiology Fellowship at the prestigious AIIMS where I trained under big names, besides imbibing the AIIMS culture of excellence. In, 1988, joining Escorts Heart Institute under the leadership of Dr Naresh Trehan and being sent to train at France in 1994 under Prof Alian Cribier- the father of modern percutaneous aortic valvuloplasty was another big milestone for me.

Seeing the field of interventions from early days of balloon to now complex cases with stents has been something I have been fortunate to witness. Being editor of IHJ, 2006-2008 and now starting the 'Recent Advances of Cardiology'- to the Year Book since last two years is also a major achievement. Also a new journal-The Journal of Current Cardiology (JCC), has been started.

What makes Indian healthcare and doctors so unique?

Indian healthcare is affordable and best value for price in the world. The other advantage is 24x7 access that patients have to a doctor, unlike in the west where the waiting period for an appointment can extend from weeks to even months! As professionals we overwhelm ourselves with work neglecting our health, causing early burn out, developing health issues and have no time for hobbies. Only a fit doctor can provide better care to the patients. I believe that job is a part of your life, not your entire life and for a right work-life balance, more group practices and better interpersonal understanding are necessary.

What is your message for aspiring cardiologists?

To the young doctors, I would say that cardiology is a very exciting branch, where you can deliver a lot of good to the society, and save many lives. Cardiology is not dead as more exciting innovations are yet to happen. Be prepared that the medical profession demands you to be mentally strong and tech savvy. Also, in today's world being adept with soft skills is an added advantage. Life is not only about you, but a team game, so build a good rapport with everyone if you have to go a long way.